

The Sunlit Hills of Greece

The sunlit hills of Greece roll down to a bright blue sea, dotted with olive groves, white marble columns, and little towns where everyone knows your name. High above, hidden in the clouds of Mount Olympus, the gods watch over the world, and the hills are full of wonders: riddling sphinxes, kindly centaurs, shy satyrs, and nymphs who sing by the springs. Here a hero is not the strongest or the loudest, but the one who keeps a cool head, asks good questions, and stands by a friend. The grandest deeds are done by being clever and brave and kind. Even a fearsome guardian, met with courage and a fair word, often turns out to be lonelier than it is wicked.

Who's Who and What's What

Places

Mount Olympus - The cloud-wrapped mountain where the gods live, watching over the sunlit hills from far above.

The Olive Town - A little white town of terracotta roofs and olive trees, the heroes' home, where the spring has fallen quiet.

The Riddle Gate - A marble gate on the hill road, guarded by a sphinx who lets pass only those who answer a riddle with a cool head.

The Singing Spring - The spring of the nymphs high in the hills, whose song once filled every well in the valley. It has gone silent.

The Winding Maze - A maze of old stone walls and hedges where it is easy to get lost without a thread to follow.

Characters

Athena - The goddess of wisdom and good ideas, who smiles on heroes that win by thinking and caring rather than by force.

Daphne the Olive-Keeper - The kind old keeper of the town's olive grove, who knows every story of the hills and sends the heroes to wake the spring.

Creatures

Bramble the Satyr - A cheerful, goat-legged satyr of the woods who loves jokes and hands out helpful hints to travellers he likes.

Chiron the Centaur - The wisest and kindest of the centaurs, half horse and half person, a teacher of heroes who believes the best deeds are gentle ones.

The Lonely Cyclops - A huge one-eyed giant who guards the spring. He looks fearsome, but he is really just lonely, and a kind word and a shared honey cake do more than any sword.

The Riddle Sphinx - A great winged sphinx with a lion's body and a kind, clever face, who guards the gate and asks riddles. She is fair, not cruel, and a good answer or a brave guess opens the way.

The Singing Nymphs - Gentle spirits of the spring whose singing makes the water flow. When they are happy, every well in the valley fills again.

Items

The Golden Thread - A ball of shining thread. Tie one end at the entrance and you can always find your way back out of the maze.

The Honey Cake - A small sweet cake. Shared with a lonely guardian, it can turn a scowl into a smile.

The Little Lyre - A small harp. A simple tune played from the heart can wake the song of the spring.

Words to Know

Courage - A steady heart in a scary moment. Courage is not being unafraid; it is being kind and clever even when you are afraid.

Heart - Care for others. In this world the greatest heroes are the ones who help, share, and stand by a friend.

Wits - Quick thinking and good questions. In these hills, wits open more doors than strength.

The Singing Spring: Idea Bank

Improv fuel for when a child goes happily off-script. Pull from these freely; none of it can break the story. Everything here is brave and kind, in keeping with these hills, where heroes win by wits, courage, and heart, never by force.

The three hero qualities

Wits: spotting a clue others miss, asking the one good question, solving a riddle, reading the lay of the land, a clever plan, turning a problem upside down, remembering an old story that helps.

Courage: taking the first step on a dark path, speaking gently to something fearsome, owning up to a mistake, trying again after a miss, standing in front of a friend, keeping a steady voice when your knees shake.

Heart: sharing food, asking a stranger's name, offering friendship, comforting a sad creature, keeping a promise, cheering up a companion, choosing the kind way over the easy way.

Helpful friends along the way

- **Bramble the Satyr** pops up with jokes and hints whenever the heroes are stuck.
- **Chiron the Centaur**, wisest of teachers, might trot by to offer a calm word.
- The **Singing Nymphs** of the spring reward kindness with a song.
- The **Riddle Sphinx** is stern at her gate but warm once you have answered.
- Even the **Lonely Cyclops** becomes a gentle friend who carries the heroes on his shoulders for fun.

Handy things to find or build

- The **golden thread** for any maze or dark place.
- The **honey cake**, and other small gifts: a ripe fig, a flower crown, a smooth river stone, a token of friendship.
- The **little lyre**, a set of pan-pipes, a bright song, a brave shout that echoes.
- An olive branch for peace, a water skin, a sun hat, a map drawn in the dust, a lucky knucklebone.

Places to wander

A sunlit olive grove, a marble temple full of echoes, a cool cave behind a waterfall, a meadow of poppies, a harbour of little fishing boats, a hilltop where you can see the whole sea.

Mini-challenges

Cross stepping stones in the right order, match a god to their symbol, calm a nervous goat, finish a half-remembered song, share out fruit so everyone gets a fair piece, find the one path that catches the morning sun.

Happy rewards

A laurel crown, a ride on the cyclops's shoulders, a new riddle to take home, a song the nymphs teach you, a basket of figs, or a wink from a goddess. Every reward is something to feel proud of; nothing is ever taken away.

Stories in this world

The Singing Spring (older). The Singing Spring has gone quiet.

Wits and Wonder

World Book

<https://github.com/agigante80/wits-and-wonder>

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Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.